

Ichthyosaurs

The ichthyosaurs were the largest sea-dwelling reptiles of all time. They evolved from land-living reptiles that adapted so well to life in the sea that some species came to resemble dolphins. Like dolphins, they fed, bred, and gave birth in water but had to return to the surface to breathe air.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Large eyes for good underwater vision
- Flippers for steering and balance
- Vertical tail fin
- Gave birth to live babies rather than laying eggs
- Lungs for breathing air

When

Ichthyosaurs lived from about 245 million years ago (Triassic Period) to nearly 90 million years ago (Cretaceous Period).



Shonisaurus

SHON-ee-sore-us



- **When** 225–208 million years ago (Late Triassic)
- **Fossil location** N. America
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** Up to 70 ft (20 m)
- **Diet** Fish, squid

Shonisaurus was like a cross between a whale and a dolphin, with an enormous body but a long, slender snout. Giant eyes and toothlessness in adults suggest it was a deep-diving squid hunter. One whale-sized specimen found in Canada was 70 ft (20 m) long—the largest marine reptile ever found.